

REVIVING THE CLASSIC
(from top, left) Stills from *The Tragedy of Macbeth*; *Joji*; *Mandaar*; and *Throne of Blood*

MORE THAN ANY OF SHAKESPEARE'S OTHER WORKS, *MACBETH* HAS BEEN BROUGHT TO THE SCREEN ACROSS DIFFERENT CULTURES AND MILIEUS

superstitious reasons) has been brought to the screen across different cultures and milieus. What is it about *Macbeth* that so appeals to filmmakers, from legends such as Orson Welles, Akira Kurosawa and Roman Polanski to the makers of today's web series? Perhaps it's the unforgiving darkness of the story (both protagonists, Macbeth and Lady Macbeth, commit crimes and descend into crippling paranoia or guilt). Or it could be the many set-pieces that make for powerful imagery, like Lady Macbeth's handwashing. Or the witches: nearly every version has found an inventive way to depict them—most amusingly perhaps in Vishal Bhardwaj's *Maqbool* (2003), where two gossipy cops fill in for the prophesying crones.

Even last year's Malayalam film *Joji*, though only tenuously inspired by *Macbeth*, does witty things with some of the play's iconic moments: with the story playing out in Covid time, the instruction "Put on a mask and go there" is a practical one, but also a nod to the many mask references ("False face must hide what the false heart doth know") in the original work.

On the one hand, non-Anglophone adaptations like *Mandaar* and *Joji* provide their own spins on Shakespeare's prose and on key passages: take the use of Noh theatre elements in Kurosawa's *Throne of Blood* (1957), which brings a still, eerie quality to scenes such as the appearance of Banquo's ghost. On the other hand, there are English versions that offer straightforward treatments of the verse but present familiar scenes in new ways. The latter type is currently represented by Joel Coen's *The Tragedy of Macbeth* (Apple TV+), so stunningly shot in black-and-white that the over-used cliché 'every frame looks like a painting' really seems to apply here. An alienating, dread-filled atmosphere is created by the framing and set design, which includes giant hallways and endless corridors.

And yet, even a 'pure' *Macbeth* like this one can have off-kilter moments that take licence with Shakespeare's words. In the scene where Macbeth thinks he sees a dagger directing him towards Duncan's room, the illusory weapon is presented as a bright vertical shape on a door far away, and his physical gestures don't quite match the words of his soliloquy, which adds to the viewer's dislocation. "Come, let me clutch thee," Macbeth says to the dagger, followed by "I have thee not and yet I see thee still". The directors who have tried to bring this strange, haunting play to the screen must often have felt the same way about their elusive source material. ■

–Jai Arjun Singh

SHAKING UP SHAKESPEARE

Films that successfully adapted the Bard's work



ANGOOR (1982)

Gulzar's take on *A Comedy of Errors*—with two pairs of twins caught in an identity switch that becomes progressively manic—was one of the high points of the 1980s' Middle Cinema.



HAMLET (1996)

Of the many *Hamlet* films, Kenneth Branagh's may be the most daring, since it retains the full text of the play—which results in a four-hour epic. But Branagh's visual sense along with the talents of a huge cast makes it deeply rewarding.

GOLIYON KI RAASLEELA RAM-LEELA (2013)

Sanjay Leela Bhansali's brand of filmmaking isn't to all tastes, but this opulent, darkly poetic reimagining of *Romeo and Juliet* is one of our best mainstream Shakespeare films, with two lovers who seem as passionate about guns as about each other.

